# Midterm Presentation: Country Selection

Student brief | Business Projects WT 2026/27 | Case: Julius Meinl, entering Latin America

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*Yellow text in square brackets is still to be confirmed by the instructor.*

## 1 At a glance

| | |
|---|---|
| **Task** | Rank six Latin American countries for Julius Meinl with a transparent scoring model, test how stable the ranking is, recommend where Julius Meinl should focus, and analyse the competitors in one market (Part B). |
| **Countries** | Argentina, Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Mexico and Uruguay. All groups compare the same six. |
| **Format** | Group presentation of 20 minutes plus one Excel file with your model. Discussion time: [x minutes]. |
| **Weight** | 30 % of the course grade (Presentation 2 of 3). |
| **Presentation** | Session 5: [date, time, room] |
| **Files due** | [date and time] on Canvas: one presentation file and one Excel file, named GroupX_Midterm and GroupX_Midterm_Model. |
| **Coaching** | Sessions 3 and 4: a progress report of about 5 minutes per group (see section 12). |
| **Builds on** | The scoring tool you recommended in your content presentation (Presentation 1). |
| **AI** | Encouraged. List every tool you used and check every number (section 10). |

## 2 The case in brief

Julius Meinl is a family-owned Viennese coffee roaster, founded in 1862 and now in its fifth generation. It sells in more than 70 countries, mostly through local distribution partners, in hospitality (cafés, restaurants and hotels, HoReCa) and in grocery retail. It has no own sales organisation in export markets, so the partner is the sales force. In Latin America Julius Meinl is not present, or only marginally.

The company asks three questions: **which** Latin American market should it enter, **how** could entry look and with what kind of partner, and **how** should the brand be positioned and marketed? Your midterm answers the first question. The final presentation answers the other two.

Julius Meinl has no preferred country. It wants to learn from your work, and different answers from different groups are welcome. It values three things: a recommendation it could act on (not a list of options), evidence it can follow including where the evidence is thin, and a clear statement of what you would **not** do, and why.

### The hard question your selection must keep in mind

Several of these countries grow and roast their own coffee. Why would cafés, hotels, retailers and consumers there choose a coffee brand from Vienna, and who exactly would do so?

Julius Meinl sells Viennese coffee house culture (service, hospitality, the idea of taking time for a cup of coffee) rather than the bean itself. Its own assumption is that this works where a European-influenced coffee culture already exists and where hotels serve many European guests. This is unverified. Your analysis can support or challenge it.

**Ground rules.** Use public data only. Julius Meinl provides no internal figures (sales, margins, prices, partner names) and you do not need them. If you contact companies or

people for your research, you do so as students on a university project, not on behalf of Julius Meinl. Julius Meinl has offered feedback on your market selection once the rankings are in. Its Group Export team answers questions that are bundled for the whole course: collect yours and send them to the instructor [process to be confirmed].

## 3 What you deliver

**Part A: country selection (the core of the midterm).** A scoring model that ranks the six countries on criteria derived from Julius Meinl's own priorities, a robustness analysis, and a recommendation.

**Part B: market and competitor analysis.** A focused analysis of the competitive situation in one country: [the country assigned to your group in session x / the country your own ranking puts first; to be confirmed]. Section 8 describes the content.

**Suggested time budget** for the 20 minutes:

| Block | Content | Minutes |
|---|---|---|
| 1 Decision and criteria | Case in one slide, the decision your model makes, criteria framework | 3 |
| 2 Data and method | Indicators and data, normalisation, weights and where they come from | 4 |
| 3 Results | Ranking, scores by dimension, what drives the result | 3 |
| 4 Robustness | What happens to the ranking when assumptions change | 3 |
| 5 Recommendation and limits | Where to focus, what not to do, what would change your mind | 2 |
| 6 Part B | Competitor analysis of one country | 4 |
| 7 Wrap-up | Three key messages | 1 |

Lead with the answer: show your recommendation on slide 2, then show how you got there. Put technical detail (full data tables, formulas) in an appendix.

## 4 Part A in eight steps

The steps follow the standard logic of composite indicators and weighted scoring (OECD/JRC, Cavusgil). Each step lists what to hand in; the Excel file in section 9 mirrors these steps.

### Step 1 Frame the decision

Write one sentence that says what your model decides, for example: "Which of the six countries offers Julius Meinl the best prospects for launching a premium coffee brand through local partners in hospitality and retail?" State your time horizon and that the unit is the country. **Hand in:** the decision sentence (Excel README sheet and slide 2).

### Step 2 Choose criteria and indicators

Use Julius Meinl's six dimensions as the backbone and make each measurable (section 5 gives candidates and sources). Julius Meinl fixes the dimensions; how you measure and weight them is yours to decide. Add criteria you consider relevant, and justify your weighting and your choice of tool. Rules:

- 8 to 14 indicators in total, each available for all six countries. More indicators do not make a better model.
- Cover **attractiveness** (size, growth, spending power) and **accessibility** (distance, import conditions, risk). Attractive markets that are hard to reach are a classic trap (Papadopoulos et al.).

- Avoid double counting: GDP, population and imports move together. Use one indicator per idea or group them.
- Fix the **direction** of every indicator (higher is better or worse).
- Qualitative criteria (coffee culture, competition) need a scoring rubric with defined anchors, for example 1 to 5 with a sentence per level. Two team members score independently, then agree.

**Hand in:** criteria sheet with definition, Julius Meinl dimension, direction, rationale and source.

### Step 3 Collect the data

Use the latest year available and note it. Record unit, year, URL and date of access for every number. Decide how to treat missing values (substitute a comparable indicator, drop the indicator, or impute) and document it. Check size effects: Brazil and Mexico are very large, Uruguay is small, so prefer per-capita and share indicators for attractiveness and use totals only where size itself matters. **Hand in:** data sheet and sources sheet.

### Step 4 Normalise

Bring all indicators to the same 0 to 100 scale and reverse those where lower is better:

- Higher is better: score = 100 x (x - min) / (max - min)
- Lower is better: score = 100 x (max - x) / (max - min)

**Caution with six countries:** min-max scaling gives the best country 100 and the weakest 0 on every indicator, even if the real gap is tiny. This exaggerates small differences. Therefore show a second variant, for example fixed "goalposts" (min and max taken from a wider reference set such as all Latin American countries), z-scores, or ranks, and explain which you chose (Pollesch and Dale; JRC pocket guide). **Hand in:** normalised sheet with live formulas.

### Step 5 Set the weights

Use the weighting approach you recommended in Presentation 1 and justify it with the case: Julius Meinl says, for example, that hotels matter most, that it targets premium buyers, and that success depends on the local partner. Section 6 compares the main methods. Document who judged, how the individual judgements were combined, and (for AHP) the consistency ratio. Set your weights **before** you look at the ranking and write them down. **Hand in:** weights sheet with method and derivation.

### Step 6 Aggregate

Baseline: weighted sum, Score(country) = sum of weight x normalised score. A large market can then offset a poor business climate (full compensation). If some conditions are knock-outs for Julius Meinl (for example, import barriers that make premium pricing impossible), add a non-compensatory filter first, as in the classic screening funnel (Cavusgil 1985): countries that fail the threshold are excluded before scoring. Explain your choice. **Hand in:** scores and ranking sheet (SUMPRODUCT and RANK formulas).

### Step 7 Test robustness (required)

A ranking is decision support, not truth. Run at least **three** of these tests and report the result in one table or chart (rank of each country under each test):

- **Other weights:** equal weights, and a second weighting method (for example BWM if you used AHP).
- **Other normalisation:** min-max against z-scores or ranks.
- **Weight noise:** change each weight by plus or minus 20 %, or draw 1,000 random weight sets and record each country's best and worst rank (RAND in Excel, or Python/R).
- **Leave one out:** drop one indicator, or one dimension, at a time.
- **Other aggregation:** weighted geometric mean or TOPSIS instead of the weighted sum.

Answer in words: Is the top country stable? Which choices change the order? **Hand in:** robustness sheet and one slide.

### Step 8 Interpret and recommend

Turn the ranking into a decision: a shortlist of two or three countries, your recommended priority country, the countries you would **not** enter now and why, and what would change your mind. Connect the result to the hard question in section 2. Be open about limits: proxy indicators, data quality, subjective weights, and that Mexico is not in South America. Most indices were built for other exporters (the globalEDGE index, for example, takes a US perspective), so adapt to the view from Vienna: distance, EU import conditions and the Julius Meinl business model. **Hand in:** recommendation slide and limitations slide.

## 5 From Julius Meinl's six dimensions to indicators

This is a starting point, not a prescription. Choose what you can measure for all six countries and justify additions. Check each source for the latest edition.

| Dimension | Julius Meinl asks | Candidate indicators | Possible sources |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Premium coffee segment** | Size in hospitality and in retail | Household consumption per capita; GDP per capita (PPP) as proxies<br>Value and growth of the coffee category (retail and out-of-home) if available<br>Number of specialty cafés in the capital and the two largest cities (own count, define the rule) | World Bank WDI; Euromonitor Passport and Statista (WU library); USDA FAS coffee reports; own online count |
| **Tourism and hotels** | Visitor volume, origin, international hotel groups | International tourist arrivals and tourism receipts<br>Share of visitors from Europe and North America, if available<br>International-brand hotels in the capital (own count, define the rule) | WDI (UN Tourism data); national tourism statistics; hotel group and booking websites (note date and method) |
| **Purchasing power** | Economic development, who can pay a premium price | GDP per capita (PPP); household consumption per capita<br>Income inequality as a modifier<br>Inflation and exchange-rate stability | WDI; IMF World Economic Outlook |
| **Competitive landscape** | Which premium brands, at what price | Presence of international premium brands (supermarkets, online shops, hotels)<br>Price of a premium 250 g pack; price of an espresso in premium cafés<br>Strength of local roasters (qualitative rubric) | Own online observation (section 8); Euromonitor company shares; USDA FAS |
| **Import and regulation** | Tariffs, certification, what applies to EU goods | Applied tariff for roasted coffee (HS 0901.21) for EU origin; trade agreement with the EU<br>Product, labelling and certification requirements<br>Logistics and regulatory quality | EU Access2Markets; WTO tariff data; World Bank LPI and WGI; B-READY (check coverage) |
| **Coffee culture** | How coffee is drunk and how much outside the home | Domestic coffee consumption per capita<br>Out-of-home and café culture (qualitative rubric)<br>European influence (qualitative rubric)<br>Domestic production (competition, but also affinity) | International Coffee Organization statistics; USDA FAS; Euromonitor; industry and travel reports |

**Your additions** (justify each): geographic, cultural and administrative distance from Austria (CAGE; CEPII Gravity, Hofstede with its validity critique), projected growth (IMF WEO), country risk (Coface or Allianz Trade, WGI). Links to the data portals are in section 14. Do not assume the current status of trade agreements or tariffs: look it up and record the date.

## 6 Weighting and aggregation: your toolbox

Choose the method you recommended in Presentation 1. This table is a reminder, not a menu to copy from.

| Method | How the weights arise | Good for | Watch out |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Direct rating or point allocation** | Rate each criterion 0 to 100, or distribute 100 points (Bottomley and Doyle 2001). Anchor the most important criterion at 100. | Fast, transparent start; team discussion | States importance but no trade-offs |
| **Rank-order centroid (ROC)** | The team only ranks the criteria. Weight of rank i among n criteria: (1/n) x sum of 1/k for k = i to n (Barron and Barrett 1996). | A team that can rank but not quantify | Steep weights: the top criterion dominates |
| **AHP** | Pairwise comparisons on a 1 to 9 scale; weights from the eigenvector or geometric mean; consistency ratio below 0.10 (Saaty 1990). | Hard-to-rank criteria; free Excel template | n(n-1)/2 judgements: keep to about 7 criteria per level |
| **Best-Worst Method** | Pick the best and the worst criterion and compare all others to them: 2n-3 comparisons (Rezaei 2015). | Fewer judgements than AHP; Excel Solver | Needs a solver; still subjective |
| **Entropy or CRITIC** | Objective: weights from the variation in the data (entropy) or variation and correlation (CRITIC). | A comparison against your own weights | With six countries very unstable; use only as a check |
| **Equal weights** | Every indicator the same. | A benchmark in the robustness tests | Not neutral: it implies trade-off rates (Decancq and Lugo 2013) |

For aggregation, start with the weighted sum. Compare it with a weighted geometric mean (less compensation: a very weak dimension pulls the score down) or TOPSIS (distance to the best and worst country) when you test robustness.

**Worked mini-example of the weighted sum.** Three indicators with weights 50, 30 and 20. Country X scores 80, 40 and 60, country Y scores 50, 90 and 70. X: 0.5 x 80 + 0.3 x 40 + 0.2 x 60 = 64. Y: 0.5 x 50 + 0.3 x 90 + 0.2 x 70 = 66. Y wins by 2 points. If the weights were 60, 20 and 20, X would score 68 and Y 62: the ranking flips. This is why Step 7 is required.

## 7 The presentation

- 20 minutes. Rehearse to time. Slide limit: [to be confirmed, for example 20 slides plus appendix]. Every slide has an action title that states its message.
- Show results visually: a ranking chart, a score-by-dimension chart, a rank-range chart for robustness. Avoid slides that only list formulas.
- Every number on a slide carries its source in a footnote (short name and year); the full reference is in the Excel sources sheet.
- Make your model understandable in two minutes: criteria, weights, and what the ranking looks like. Details go to the appendix.
- Be ready for questions on weights, data choices and robustness. Julius Meinl's questions will be "why this country?" and "what would you not do?"

## 8 Part B: market and competitor analysis

Deepen your view of one country ([assignment to be confirmed, see section 3]). Cover:

- How coffee is consumed out of home and at home.
- Which premium brands are present, at which prices, and in which channels.
- How distribution works in hospitality and in retail; what kind of local partner would fit (a profile, not a name).
- Which import conditions and regulations apply to Julius Meinl.
- How the main competitors position and communicate their brands.

You can do most of this online from Vienna. Analyse the target city: menus and prices of premium cafés, shelf prices in supermarkets and online shops, online reviews, competitors' social media, and which coffee brands hotels serve. Record each observation in a **competitor table** with these columns: brand, segment (HoReCa or retail), channel, product, price and unit, positioning, communication, URL, date. Close the part with the implication for Julius Meinl: where is there room for a Viennese coffee house brand, and where is none?

## 9 The Excel file

One workbook that someone else can follow without your presentation. Sheets:

| Sheet | Content |
|---|---|
| **1 README** | Team, date, version, decision sentence, how to read the workbook, colour code |
| **2 Criteria** | Indicator, Julius Meinl dimension, definition, direction, rationale, source |
| **3 Data** | Raw values (rows: countries; columns: indicators) with unit and year above each column; qualitative scores with rubric |
| **4 Normalised** | Normalised scores by formula; the second variant |
| **5 Weights** | Method, judgements, resulting weights (sum 100), consistency check |
| **6 Scores** | Weighted scores by SUMPRODUCT, ranking by RANK; scores by dimension |
| **7 Robustness** | Tests and the resulting ranks for each country |
| **8 Competitors** | Competitor table for Part B |
| **9 Sources** | Every source with URL, date accessed, who collected it |

Rules: results are produced by formulas, not pasted values; inputs and formulas are visibly different (for example blue input cells); no hidden sheets or hard-coded numbers in the score sheet.

## 10 Use of AI

You are explicitly encouraged to use (generative) AI tools, for example to find and summarise sources, explain a method, write Excel formulas or Python/R code, check your model for errors, or draft slides. Rules:

- An AI answer is **not a source**. Every figure must be traceable to a primary source with URL and date. Verify every number an AI tool gives you.
- Be honest: list all tools you used and what you used them for (README sheet and last slide).
- You are responsible for the content. Be ready to explain every choice in your model.
- As in the syllabus, you are graded on the quality, innovativeness and variety of your sources.

## 11 How the midterm is assessed

The midterm is graded as a group and counts 30 % of the course grade. Indicative weighting of the criteria: [to be confirmed].

| Criterion | What we look for | Weight |
|---|---|---|
| **Fit to the case** | Criteria derived from Julius Meinl's dimensions; the view from Vienna; the hard question is addressed | 15 % |
| **Data quality and documentation** | Named sources, years and units; missing data handled openly; everything traceable | 15 % |
| **Method** | Tool from Presentation 1 applied correctly; normalisation and weights justified; model reproducible in Excel | 20 % |
| **Robustness** | At least three tests; honest reading of what they show | 15 % |
| **Insight and recommendation** | Clear and actionable; says what not to do; states uncertainty; Part B adds real competitor insight | 20 % |
| **Presentation and Excel** | Structure, timing, visuals, answers to questions; clear workbook | 15 % |

## 12 Timeline and coaching

| When | What |
|---|---|
| **Before session 3** | Draft criteria framework; data plan; first data for at least three indicators; weighting method chosen |
| **Session 3** | Progress report (about 5 minutes): criteria, data status, open questions |
| **Before session 4** | Complete data, normalisation, weights, first ranking |
| **Session 4** | Progress report (about 5 minutes): results and first robustness checks |
| **Between sessions 4 and 5** | Finish robustness and recommendation; Part B; rehearse; submit the files by [deadline] |
| **Session 5** | Midterm presentation |

## 13 Common pitfalls

- **Too many indicators.** Twenty indicators hide what matters. Keep to 8 to 14.
- **Double counting.** GDP, population and imports are strongly correlated.
- **Min-max with six countries.** It stretches tiny differences. Show a second normalisation.
- **Mixed years, units or totals and per-capita values.** Fix them in the data sheet before scoring.
- **Weights that reproduce the ranking you expected.** Fix and document weights before you see results.
- **Treating the ranking as the truth.** Report rank ranges and say what would change the order.
- **Ignoring Julius Meinl's model.** A big market without hotels, premium buyers or a feasible partner may not fit.
- **Unsourced or unchecked AI numbers.**
- **No "what not to do".** A recommendation includes the countries you would not enter now.

# 14 Starting resources

Selected from the instructor's background collection of 248 annotated sources: github.com/arnefloh-wu/scoring-method-search

### Methods and guides

- JRC: 10-step pocket guide to composite indicators (free): https://knowledge4policy.ec.europa.eu/composite-indicators/toolkit_en/your-10-step-pocket-guide-composite-indicators-scoreboards_en
- OECD/JRC: Handbook on constructing composite indicators (free): https://doi.org/10.1787/9789264043466-en
- Greco et al. (2019): weighting and aggregation in composite indices (open access): https://doi.org/10.1007/s11205-017-1832-9
- BPMSG: AHP Excel template (free): https://bpmsg.com/new-ahp-excel-template-with-multiple-inputs/
- Best-Worst Method solvers (free): https://bestworstmethod.com/
- JRC COIN Tool, Excel composite indicators (free): https://knowledge4policy.ec.europa.eu/composite-indicators/coin-tool_en

### Market selection logic

- globalEDGE Market Potential Index: eight dimensions with published weights (25, 15, 12.5, 12.5, 10, 10, 7.5, 7.5): https://globaledge.msu.edu/mpi
- Cavusgil (1997): measuring the potential of emerging markets (WU library): https://doi.org/10.1016/S0007-6813%2897%2990030-6
- Ghemawat (2001): Distance still matters, the CAGE framework (WU library): https://hbr.org/2001/09/distance-still-matters-the-hard-reality-of-global-expansion
- Musso and Francioni: how smaller firms select foreign markets (open access): https://doi.org/10.5539/ijms.v4n6p44
- Pollesch and Dale (2016): normalisation choices (WU library): https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ecolecon.2016.06.018

### Benchmarks and examples

- ITC Export Potential Map, methodology (free): https://umbraco.exportpotential.intracen.org/media/cklh2pi5/epa-methodology_230627.pdf
- Kearney Global Retail Development Index (free): https://www.kearney.com/industry/consumer-retail/global-retail-development-index
- Eurazeo: International Expansion Playbook (free): https://www.eurazeo.com/sites/default/files/2023-10/Eurazeo-International-Expansion-Playbook-GROWTH.pdf
- Optional case about coffee: The Espresso Lane to Global Markets, illy (Ivey Publishing, paid): https://www.iveypublishing.ca/s/product/the-espresso-lane-to-global-markets/01t5c00000CwqzKAAR
- IFC PAYG Market Attractiveness Index, an Excel tool with user guide (free): https://www.lightingglobal.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/11/IFC-PAYG-market-attractiveness-index-USER-GUIDE-AND-DATA-1Oct2018.pdf

### Data

- World Bank World Development Indicators: https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators
- IMF World Economic Outlook: https://data.imf.org/datasets/WEO
- World Bank Worldwide Governance Indicators: https://www.worldbank.org/en/publication/worldwide-governance-indicators
- EU Access2Markets (tariffs, requirements, rules of origin for EU exporters): https://trade.ec.europa.eu/access-to-markets/en/content/what-access2markets-0
- WTO tariff and trade data: https://stats.wto.org/
- CEPII Gravity database (distance, language; free login): https://www.cepii.fr/CEPII/en/bdd_modele/bdd_modele_item.asp?id=8
- Hofstede dimension data matrix: https://geerthofstede.com/research-and-vsm/dimension-data-matrix/
- Coface country risk assessments: https://www.coface.com/news-economy-and-insights/business-risk-dashboard/country-risk-files
- Euromonitor Passport (WU library): https://www.euromonitor.com/our-expertise/passport
- Statista (WU library): https://www.statista.com/
- International Coffee Organization (coffee statistics) and USDA Foreign Agricultural Service (annual coffee reports by country): search the two sites for your countries: https://www.ico.org/